

Episode 99: Once Upon a Time... (61) – *COO* And Into the Distance...

Just recently, cicadas were noisily crying even at night, but last night I suddenly noticed the cicada voices had disappeared and somehow changed to autumn insects' voices. Tokyo nights have become quite cool.

Still, daytime remains hot. On such a hot Sunday, *Ultimate!! Mecha-Mote Chairman* staff went on "fashionable location scouting" to Harajuku-Shibuya. Led by Director Kosaka, with producer, two character designers, art director and others - 9 people total wandering around. While I buy magazines regularly, actually going out to experience "live samples (laughs)" is important.

Right in the middle of summer clearance sales. Not "mecha-mote" but "mecha-komi (crowded) (tears)" - we energetically covered Takeshita Street, Shibuya 109, etc. Having women along definitely makes fashionable shops easier to enter (laughs). "109" would be absolutely impossible for me alone (laughs).

But the crowds were probably correct. While seeing shops and products was one purpose, most importantly, the customers gathering in those areas were the best samples. Some people were cool, others not, but both were exactly "live samples."

So I was staring quite intently at customers and shop staff. Shop staff usually wear their store's clothes, so their styling was also educational. When I made eye contact, I'd smile nicely (laughs). ←Ah, suspicious...

Oh my... (sweat).

Such "fashionable location scouting" needs to happen seasonally. When's next? Around late October maybe?

The sheer number of people was overwhelming though (laughs).

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home production faced its second summer. This was 1993. Main episode work was mostly complete, with parallel retake work beginning. Release was officially decided for that winter, December. Delivery schedule decided for autumn. Finally the final phase.

On a certain day near summer's end, a terrible incident occurred. Kadokawa Haruki arrested! For narcotics violations among other charges - the very head of film production was arrested.

"What will happen? To COO?" An unpleasant feeling swirled among us production staff. "Surely not a release delay, right?"

While COO wasn't directly at fault, so it probably wouldn't come to that, still the rising mood and publicity felt dampened - or rather doused - leaving us very unsettled.

Come to think of it, the previous spring, we suddenly had a staff introduction for Kadokawa Haruki regarding COO, with us main staff gathered in Oizumi Studio's 3rd floor large conference room. Kadokawa Haruki appeared there. He had overwhelming presence, a powerful aura that brightened the room. He gave us staff an inspiring speech, and I was quite moved at the time.

Even in such circumstances, production continued.

I've forgotten exact dates by now, but once sound-related work finished, we decided to watch through everything once. The so-called "with sound" screening. While we issue detailed retakes as rushes come up, watching everything from start to finish sometimes reveals hidden retakes. So it's like final retake identification. We approached the "with sound" screening quite nervously.

No, we were more excited than nervous.

"What will those screens look like with dialogue and sound added?"

That day from morning, I was strangely high-energy.

Toei Animation Oizumi Studio's 3rd floor screening room gathered all staff, screening by reel (about 10+ minutes each) in order. Main episode about 2 hours. We were in the screening room about 4 hours total. While some screens still had retake work remaining, what had colour throughout was mostly complete.

It was quite moving!

A 2-hour feature film was my first experience. About a year and a bit with various difficulties. The results were here. Ah, good. While the director and other staff discussed various additional retakes, I was alone in a storm of emotion.

Then October. At Toei Chemical's Chofu screening room, *Coo: Far From Home*'s first screening was held. I remember it was quite early morning. Sitting front row centre (I always watch first screenings from this seat), I checked the first print. Secretly, several retakes remained with "oops" moments (laughs), but it was still magnificent. When I confirmed "Colour Design: Tsujita Kunio" in the ending credits, my emotions swelled even larger. I felt a rush of having accomplished something.

Several days later, the completion premiere was held at Oizumi Toei Studios' screening room. Kadokawa Haruki couldn't attend (laughs), but original author Kageyama Tamio came.

After the screening, at the wrap party in the studio cafeteria, I actually got to talk with Kageyama-san! "Kageyama-san, when this COO was published, I properly bought and

read the book, and being a huge fan of this story, for someone like me to be involved in this movie..." I was extremely excited (burst). Kageyama-san listened happily to my story. And then I realised:

"Ah! I should have gotten my first edition signed!"

A lifelong regret.

When I told Kageyama-san this, he said "Then send it to my office. I'll sign it (laughs)" and gave me his office business card. But I couldn't be so bold as to request a signature. That became another good memory.

Coo: Far From Home had its nationwide release that winter. Unfortunately it didn't become a big hit and still hasn't become a DVD (laughs).

Even so, for me it was probably a work that became a huge treasure.

As a side note, among promotional goods distributed to staff during production was a memo pad, which I actually still treasure and use. Using it, or rather too precious to use (laughs). It's still firmly placed on my Oizumi Studio desk. Maybe it's like a good luck charm now? (laughs)

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